Khalsa was openly demanding the creation of Khalistan. Therefore their demand for the release of Bhindranwale created an impression that the organization which demanded Khalistan had close links with Bhindranwale.

The hijacking ended with an operation by Pakistani commandos. All the five hijackers including Gajinder Singh were tried in Pakistan and sentenced to life. Following the hijacking, the Government of India imposed a ten-year ban on the Dal Khalsa in 1982, which was lifted in 1992. After lying low for fifteen years, the Dal Khalsa staged a political comeback in Punjab in 1998, which coincided with the so-called release of the five hijackers from prison in Pakistan. Two of the five, Tejinder Pal Singh and Satnam Singh, who were deported, were finally discharged from the case by a Delhi court in 2011. Gajinder Singh, as head of Dal Khalsa International (DKI), remains in exile in Pakistan.

Santokh Singh, who had pleaded with Indira Gandhi for Bhindranwale's release, was shot dead in Delhi on 21 December 1981 in his car, allegedly by a rival Sikh politician. Santokh Singh was reportedly paying the legal fees for the killers facing trial in Gurbachan Singh's murder case. He also used to pay Rs 2,000 every month to the family of one of the accused, Ranjit Singh. [11]

Zail Singh and Rajiv Gandhi attended Santokh Singh's memorial service. A photograph from the event shows Zail Singh with Bhindranwale. However, Bhindranwale was not pleased to see the home minister. In his address to the congregation, he made an obvious reference to Zail Singh dyeing his beard, anathema to an orthodox Sikh. 'Anyone who has his face blackened and sandals hung round his neck and is made to sit backwards on a donkey is being punished because he has molested someone's sister or someone's mother. I am surprised to see that some people here have blackened their own faces. I do not know whose sister they have molested.' [12] Zail Singh apparently digested that insult as he felt Bhindranwale was still useful to him in Punjab and in furthering the cause of Op-2.

New R&AW missions